



free will
and
determinism

against
compatibilist
free will

A large red circle with a slight drop shadow, containing white text. The text is arranged in three lines, centered within the circle.

**against
incompatibilist
free will**

This argument seems to show that the combination of four theses — that No one has any choice about the past, no choice about the laws of nature, the no choice principle, and determinism — rules out free will.

Since the first three of these theses seem quite plausible, the argument seems to show that if determinism is true, there are no free actions — and hence that free will is incompatible with determinism.

1. Free will is incompatible with determinism.
 2. If Libertarianism is true, then there is no free will.
-

C. There is no free will.

The master argument against the reality of free will

Real/|the master argument:

The consequence argument is a defense of premise (1). If you believe in free will, and find the consequence argument persuasive, it looks tempting to reply to the master argument by denying premise (2).

But, we'll see now, this argument can also be given a plausible defense.

One way to introduce this defense is with the following quote from

David Hume:

Hume's basic thought is that there is a big difference between free actions and actions which are random or chance.

Here's a thought experiment:

Now ask yourself: is Alex's choice free? It seems very clear that it is not. It is undetermined by facts prior to the relevant run of the Randomizer, but it is random. It is not up to Alex what he does; and free actions have to be up to the person doing the action.

This suggests:

But now consider the idea that free will requires the falsity of determinism. If this is true, then it must be that free actions (or their immediate causes) are undetermined:

But consider what an undetermined act would be. It would be an action which is such that the entire history of the universe up to that point is consistent with the act either happening or not happening. So if the act happens, nothing **makes** it happen. In particular, nothing that the person who does the action, or anyone else, does makes the action happen.

One way to state the conclusion of the control argument is that free will
requires determinism.

1. If Libertarianism is true, then, if there are free actions, those actions are undetermined.
 2. If an action is undetermined, then it is random.
 3. If Libertarianism is true, then, if there are free actions, those actions are random. (1,2)
 4. No random acts are free.
-

C. If Libertarianism is true, then there are no free actions.

The control argument

But this is very bad news for free will if you found the consequence argument convincing. For that argument seems to show that free will is **incompatible** with determinism.

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“It is commonly allowed that mad-men have no liberty. But were we to judge by their actions, these have less regularity and constancy than the actions of wise-men, and consequently are farther removed from necessity. Our way of thinking in this particular is, therefore, absolutely inconsistent.”

The problem here is summed up in this quote from David Hummel:



4. If determinism is true, the laws of

3. If determined, the only one

and none has any choice about whether,

5. No one has any choice about what the laws

then DECISION happens. (3)

2. None has any choice about DIDS. ATJR.

varlatatie + the last of the



future is not just what the state of the

happened in the distant past.



nature say that if DINS ARE happy,

of interest.

1. No one has any choice about events which

the idealist that is NOT AUR

then DECISION. (4,5)

6. If determinant is true, then one has any

about whether @.

7. If none has about choice about whether P ,

if P , then Q , then one has any choice

C. If determinist is true, then no one has any

choice about DECISION (2, 6, 7)

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We can lay out this puzzle in terms of the following master argument against the

reality of free will.

Compatibility believers in free will reject premise (1). An incompatibilist

believe in free will rejects premise (2).

for (2), and one for (3).

Now, so far we have been given no reason to think that either premise (2)

or premise (3) is true. We're now going to look at two arguments — one

A large, solid orange circle with a subtle drop shadow, centered on a white background. Inside the circle, the text "against compatibilist free will" is written in white, bold, lowercase letters, arranged in three lines.

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